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Academic Appointments

Postdoctoral Scholar, University of Chicago (prior to the academic job market) *2024–Present*

Education

University of Chicago, Ph.D. Economics *2024*

Koc University, M.Sc. Economics *2018*

TOBB University of Economics & Technology, B.A. Economics & International Relations *2016*

References

Professor Ufuk Akcigit (Chair) University of Chicago Kenneth C. Griffin Department of Economics uakcigit@uchicago.edu (773) 702-0433	Professor Veronica Guerrieri University of Chicago Booth School of Business vguerrie@chicagobooth.edu (773) 834-7834
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Research and Teaching Fields

Primary: Macroeconomics, Economic Growth
Secondary: Innovation, Firm Dynamics

Job Market Paper

Spatial Allocation of Inventors, Knowledge Diffusion and Growth

Abstract: Where does innovation truly thrive? Inventive activity in the US. is strikingly concentrated in a handful of hubs. This raises compelling questions: Does further agglomeration drive innovation, or could a more dispersed approach better leverage regional spillovers? To investigate, I exploit variation in patent citation lags across US states and develop a novel endogenous growth model with mobile inventors and workers. The model integrates an exogenous knowledge network that facilitates the dynamic exchange of ideas—laying the foundation for future inventions—between locations, revealing that

inventors do not internalize how their location choice influences broader knowledge diffusion. These knowledge spillovers call for a targeted, place-based R&D subsidy to unlock latent innovation potential. Calibrating the model to data on inventor and worker allocations—and estimating the knowledge diffusion network from patent citations—I find that optimal policy would further concentrate inventors in established hubs, enhancing welfare by 1.8% in consumption-equivalent terms and boosting the economy’s long-run growth rate by 0.14 percentage points.

Working Papers

Engineering Ukraine’s Wirtschaftswunder (with Ufuk Akcigit, Somik Lall, Solomiya Shpak)

Abstract: As Ukraine emerges from the devastation of war, it faces a historic opportunity to engineer its own Wirtschaftswunder—a productivity-driven economic transformation akin to post-war West Germany. While investment-led growth may offer quick wins, it is efficiency, innovation, and institutional reform that will determine Ukraine’s long-term economic trajectory. Drawing on rich micro-level firm data spanning 25 years, this paper uncovers deep structural distortions that have suppressed creative destruction and productivity in Ukraine. It finds that business dynamism is on the decline, alongside rising market concentration among incumbent businesses, including low productivity state owned enterprises. To inform priorities for reviving business dynamism, this study develops a model of creative destruction drawing on Acemoglu et al. (2018) and Akcigit et al. (2021). The quantitative assessment highlights that policies that discipline entrenched incumbents are the bedrock for reviving business dynamism and engineer Ukraine’s Wirtschaftswunder. Policies targeting specific types of firms have limited efficacy when incumbents run wild.

Ready, Set, Unify: The Uneven Race between Trabants and BMWs (with Ufuk Akcigit, Sina Ates, Matthias Mertens, Stephen Mueller)

Abstract: Even 30 years after the reunification, regions in East Germany (the former GDR) live in considerably different economic conditions, with the average GDP per capita still about 20 percent below the average level in the West German regions. In this paper, we explore the factors that impeded faster convergence despite massive support to the East with a particular focus on technological differences and firm behavior. In the immediate aftermath of the reunification, production in the former GDR exhibited a rapid catch-up with the West with a pick-up in labor productivity. But the convergence tapered off quickly thereafter, with a stark difference between East and West German firms’ product qualities persisting ever since. We build a quantitative model of innovation, competition, and regional integration that can mimic these dynamics and provides a suitable setting to evaluate alternative policies that could have altered these dynamics. We show that large initial technological differences depressed Eastern firms’ incentives to compete and invest in technology improvements, perpetuating initial gaps. Delaying reunification, that is, opening up to competition from the West, would not help Eastern firms build up capacity. Sustained support for R&D in the East from the West could have helped shrink persistent gaps in product quality and income, although more effective alternatives appear to be subsidies to Western firms via either R&D support, with knowledge spillovers lifting also Eastern technology, or direct income support to facilitate technology transfer to the East via licensing.

Work in Progress

The Inequality-Growth Nexus: Evidence and Theory from Capital Goods Innovation

Abstract: Over the past few decades, the U.S. economy has experienced a slowdown in per capita GDP growth alongside a persistent rise in household inequality. A key driver of this divergence appears to be the increasing concentration of business assets at the top of the wealth distribution and growing inequality across firms. To explore the role of technology in this pattern, I construct a novel dataset by matching Wikipedia text descriptions of capital goods to patent texts using modern machine learning techniques.

Using this dataset, I document two main empirical findings. First, within-sector inequality across firms tends to decline following positive technology shocks to tangible capital goods. Second, innovation in tangible capital goods has been steadily declining over time. To interpret these findings, I develop an endogenous growth model with heterogeneous households, wealth inequality and capital-augmenting innovation. In the model, innovation affects inequality through its impact on the rate of return to capital: it lowers capital gains by reducing the resale value of old capital, while increasing returns via higher dividend yields on newer, more productive assets. I use the model to analyze the long-run effects of declining corporate tax rates and find that lower taxes can reduce long-run growth—challenging the conventional view that tax cuts promote innovation. The results suggest that policies aimed at reducing inequality can be compatible with, and even enhance, long-term growth.

High-Growth Firms and the Demand for Skills: Evidence from Job Postings (with Anuraag Aekka, Ufuk Akcigit, Roberto Fattal Jaef, Tatjana Kleinberg)

Measuring Productivity, Business Dynamism, and Economic Growth: The Case of Colombia and Turkiye (with Ufuk Akcigit, Maria Aristizabal-Ramirez, Seyit Cilasun, Christian Posso, Andres Zambrano)

Awards, Scholarships, and Grants

University of Chicago Neubauer Fellowship	2018–2024
Republic of Turkiye TUBITAK Fellowship	2016–2018
Koc University Scholarship	2016–2018
Graduation with distinction from TOBB ETU <i>1st in the faculty, 2nd in the class of 2016</i>	2016
59 th in Turkish National University Entrance Exam	2010

Teaching Experience

Firm Dynamics and Growth (graduate)	TA for Prof. Akcigit	Winter 2023, 2022
Economic Policy Analysis (undergraduate)	TA for Kanit Kuevibulvanich	Fall 2023, 2022
Elements of Economic Analysis (undergraduate)	TA for Suleyman Gozen	Spring 2020
Macroeconomics I (graduate)	TA for Prof. Yilmaz	Fall 2017
Math Camp (graduate)	Instructor	Summer 2017
Money and Banking (undergraduate)	TA for Prof. Demiralp	Spring 2017
Introduction to Economics (undergraduate)	TA for Prof. Usman	Fall 2016

Prior Academic Employment

Research Assistant for Prof. Akcigit, University of Chicago	2019–2021
Research Assistant for Prof. Altug and Prof. Yesiltas, Koc University	2017–2018

Professional Experience

Organizer of Growth Academy, University of Chicago	2024–2025
Organizer of ART seminars, University of Chicago	2023–present

Conferences	<i>Macroeconomics Across Time and Space</i>	<i>2024</i>
Presentations	<i>World Bank</i>	<i>2025</i>
	<i>Growth Academy</i>	<i>2025</i>
	<i>Capital Theory Seminar, University of Chicago</i>	<i>2025, 2024</i>
	<i>Applications of Economics Seminar, University of Chicago</i>	<i>2023</i>
Refereeing Activity	<i>American Economic Review: Insights</i>	

Additional Information		
Citizenship	Turkiye	
Programming Skills	Julia, Python, Matlab, R, Stata	
Languages	Turkish (Native), English (Fluent)	